AGRICULTURE & FARMERS WELFARE

SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN, *65* | BJP
Minister of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare

RIPE FOR THE NEXT AGRI REVOLUTION

Who better to helm the ministry than the man who made MP an agri powerhouse. Can he do the same for the nation?

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

PTI



Chouhan and his deputies, Ram Nath Thakur (left) and Bhagirath Choudhary

In the past 10 years, the Modi government has done fairly well in removing many of the glitches on the input side of farming. However, its attempts to reform the farm gate to market access side have seen scant success. The Centre tried to open up the segment in 2020 with three new farm laws. Only to run into extremely rough weather after the farm unions went up in arms in 2020-21. Changing tack, the government has since tried to revitalise the cooperative sector to strengthen the farm gate infrastructure in order to help farmers build capacity and storage facilities and enable them to command remunerative prices for their produce. Chouhan has a reputation for not working in "closed chambers"; he likes to meet, discuss, understand and fine-tune public policy and, as a source says, bring a "human touch to the dotted line". That trait should now come in handy in taking the states along and ensuring that the next set of reforms don't face the same headwinds. ■

Ministers of State

RAM NATH THAKUR
74 | JD(U)

↘ **Son rise** Son of Bharat Ratna awardee and late Bihar CM Karpoori Thakur, he's had stints in the cabinets of both Nitish Kumar and Lalu Prasad

BHAGIRATH CHOUDHARY, *70* | BJP

↘ **Turning fortunes** Six months ago, many had written Choudhary off after he lost in the Rajasthan assembly poll. But winning the Ajmer LS seat got him back into the reckoning

RURAL DEVELOPMENT

Bringing Villages to the Fore

The rural landscape is in the midst of a transformative journey, as multidimensional poverty sees a decline. But there is much catching up to do with rising aspirations

By AMARNATH K. MENON

The ministry's ambit involves initiatives for poverty eradication, increasing livelihood opportunities and providing a social safety net. Funds are not an issue—budgetary allocation for 2024-25 is Rs 1.85 lakh crore. The rural landscape is undergoing a transformative journey, marked by a decline in multidimensional poverty. The updated National Multidimensional Poverty Index, released by NITI Aayog in 2023, claims that 248 million people have escaped poverty between 2015-16 and 2019-21. In villages, though, along with the signs of growth, concerns too have emerged: migration of the aspirational youth to urban and semi-urban areas in search of jobs, a rise in alcohol and drug addiction and the continuing lack of hygiene and cleanliness despite the Swachh Bharat Mission initiatives. ■